

ATS-Friendly CV Checklist

Run any CV through these checks to confirm it will pass automated screening before it reaches a recruiter.

How to use: Tick each box as you check the CV. Sections 1–4 are the parser gates — a single miss here can get a CV rejected before a human ever sees it. Sections 5–8 decide how well it ranks once it is read. A CV is submission-ready only when every **FIX FIRST** item passes.

1 FILE & DELIVERY

FIX FIRST

- ☐ Saved as a **.docx** (Word) file — this is the version submitted to online applications
- ☐ Any PDF version is for visual review or printing only, not for uploading to an ATS
- ☐ All text is **selectable** — nothing is saved inside an image (test: highlight the whole CV and confirm it copies as plain text)
- ☐ Clean filename such as **Firstname_Lastname_CV.docx** — no "final", "v3", or draft tags

2 LAYOUT & STRUCTURE

FIX FIRST

- ☐ Single-column layout — or a simple two-column with all core content (experience, education) in the main column
- ☐ No **tables** used to position content
- ☐ No **text boxes**
- ☐ Nothing important sits in the document's **header or footer** area (many parsers skip these entirely)
- ☐ No key information locked inside logos, charts, graphics, or icons
- ☐ Consistent margins on all sides (roughly 2–2.5 cm / 0.7–1 inch)

3 FONTS & FORMATTING

FIX FIRST

- ☐ An **ATS-safe font** only: Calibri, Arial, Helvetica, Cambria, Georgia, or Times New Roman
- ☐ No decorative, script, or custom-installed fonts
- ☐ Body 10.5–11pt · headings 12–13pt · name 18–24pt
- ☐ Two colours maximum, no gradients or shadows
- ☐ One consistent bullet style throughout (simple round or square)
- ☐ All dates in a single format, e.g. **Jan 2020 – Mar 2023**

4 SECTION HEADINGS

FIX FIRST

- ☐ Standard heading names the ATS searches for: **Professional Summary, Work Experience, Education, Skills, Certifications**
- ☐ No creative labels like "About Me", "My Journey", or "What I Do"
- ☐ Sections ordered logically for the candidate's level (fresh graduate leads with education; experienced professional leads with experience)

5 CONTACT INFORMATION

CORE

- ☐ Name, phone, professional email, city & country, and LinkedIn URL are all present
- ☐ Contact details sit in the **body** of the document, not the header/footer
- ☐ Professional email address — no nicknames or old handles
- ☐ No photo, age, marital status, religion, or ID number — *unless* the target market (e.g. parts of the Gulf) expects it

6 KEYWORDS & CORE COMPETENCIES

CORE

- ☐ A **Core Competencies / Skills** section exists with 8–12 relevant, keyword-rich terms
- ☐ Keywords mirror the language of the target job description
- ☐ Acronyms shown with their full form once, e.g. **SEO (Search Engine Optimization)**
- ☐ Keywords read naturally inside the summary and experience — not stuffed or repeated
- ☐ The job title on the CV aligns with the role being applied for

7 CONTENT QUALITY

RANKING

- ☐ A Professional Summary of 3–5 lines, keyword-rich and specific
- ☐ Every experience bullet opens with a strong **action verb**
- ☐ **60%+ of bullets** carry a measurable result — a number, %, time saved, or revenue
- ☐ Achievements, not duty lists
- ☐ No personal pronouns (I, me, my)
- ☐ Experience in reverse-chronological order
- ☐ Correct length for the level — Student 1 page · Professional 1–2 · Executive 2

8 FINAL VERIFICATION

FIX FIRST

- ☐ Pasted into **Jobscan.co** or **Resume Worded** against a real job description
- ☐ Scored **75%+** keyword match (aim 80–90% for premium)
- ☐ Run through Grammarly — zero spelling or grammar errors
- ☐ Opened once more and confirmed the whole CV copies out as clean, readable plain text

THE VERDICT

-  **ATS-Ready.** Every "Fix First" item passes and the Jobscan score is 75%+. Safe to submit the Word file.
-  **Ranks Poorly.** The parser gates pass but Sections 6–7 are thin. It will get through screening but sit low in the results — strengthen keywords and add measurable results.
-  **Not ATS-Safe.** One or more items in Sections 1–4 failed. The CV risks being rejected before a human reads it. Fix those first, then re-test.